



Usao Community Library Foundation Storyline

Every generation has to leave something behind for the generations that follow.

Be it a road, a water source, a hospital, a place of worship, at least something!

Regardless of all these generational valuables which we indeed appreciate; sometimes, the most important thing a generation can leave behind is something perhaps not so vibrant as to easily detect the outcome yet critically impactful.

For the children, the people of Usao, that need has become increasingly evident.

Usao Sublocation, in Mbita East Division of Mbita Constituency of Homa Bay County- Kenya, is home to many children, students, young people, families and communities whose aspirations extend far beyond their immediate circumstances. Yet for many learners, access to the resources necessary to nurture those aspirations remain limited.

A pupil desires to read yet no book, no quiet place to write and comprehend. This may surely write off his/her bright future altogether

For many families, learning therefore, remains heavily constrained to what is available within the classroom which, evidently is not sufficient given the under-resourcing and that is where UCR-CENT project comes in, to go Beyond THE Classroom and bring the serenity for fruitful futuristic learning, not just to pupils, not just to students but to the community at large.

The challenge extends far beyond books.

Limited electricity and internet access further restrict opportunities for digital learning and access to information. In such an environment, the absence of a library is not simply the absence of a building filled with books. It represents the absence of a safe educational space, a place where a learner can sit quietly, explore ideas, revise, ask questions, develop a reading habit and encounter knowledge beyond the boundaries of the classroom...

Every challenge contains the possibility of a befitting response.

The story of the Usao Community Library begins with people who understand this reality because they have lived it. Alumni of Usao, Usungu, Ngodhe, Nyamaji and Uwi Primary, (Sec.) Schools, together with Dr. Benard Oloo, a lecturer at Egerton University are connected to one simple yet powerful idea:

What if the community could create the educational resource it has long needed?

Are we constructing a building? No, we are responding to the community that has pushed us forward to see what could be. We have gone, seen and we are counted faithful to return; for this, is where we belong.



This is our **vision**: *A community where every learner can access books, find a safe place to study, and have the opportunity to read, learn, grow and succeed.*

Turning this vision to reality requires more than good intentions. It requires land, It requires books, it requires people, construction materials, furniture, lighting, technical expertise, library management and sustained community participation.

And so, another chapter opens-community ownership and partnership.

The 22nd of September served as a very important day worth referencing;

The heart of USAO was pumping for another milestone. From the project leader Dr. Ben and his delegation travelling early morning from Egerton to catch up with time in USAO to Principals, Head-Teachers, Deputy's and Learners anticipating their arrival. The community members including the Chief and Area administration were in no way left behind.

Accessibility issues and stop-ups were there, *-you know our roads-* but the vision is too bright. At 10:55 am, the Egerton team is received at USAO Secondary (the centre of operation). Briefing is done and what follows is the spearheading process in the target schools.

A ground team well co-ordinated to assist in transportation to the stations.

Here's the mission:

- ✓ Bring this initiative to the ears of the target schools, (learners and teachers)
- ✓ Establish the challenges faced and for a reason, bring clarity on how this project is going to solve them.
- ✓ Engage the grade 3 learners in reading and in crayon and paper work; encourage them.

Within an hour and half- what a massive success it was- then follows another high- school hour and half session

Wait; all people must be engaged -

Our parents, brothers and sisters out of school must be engaged, (and this, is conducted through a Baraza, using the able hands of local administration). This engagement and sitting only amounts to three words: Warmth, Joy and Commitments.

The community committed land for the project. This transforms the proposed library from an externally imposed intervention into a community asset. Partners including Egerton University Library, The Reading Culture, the Kenya National Library Service and Kenyan diaspora supporters have come together around different aspects of the initiative. The Reading Culture is expected to provide the first 1,000 books, Egerton University Library will support librarian training and internship opportunities, while KNLS will provide technical guidance.



The first step is intentionally modest.

Rather than waiting for millions of shillings before anything can happen, the project begins with a practical Phase One: a functional mabati-and-wood structure designed to provide shelving for up to 10,000 books, seating for approximately 100 users and a small administrative space for the librarian. The initial phase has been designed around a KES 500,000 ceiling.

Having phase one means- it doesn't end there. P1 may have been implemented by the aforementioned but here is our take home: Subsequent phases can even accommodate as many people. So, where are growth lovers? Where are education champions?

Kindly join us in this.

Look,

The library does not begin with a magnificent building. It begins with a commitment.

It begins with: a donated land, a people giving their time, alumni remembering where they came from, partners donating books and expertise and ultimately, a community deciding that its children deserve a place to read.

Our ambition is not to fill shelves - it is to fill minds!

The proposed library will serve learners from Usao, Nyamaji, Usungu, Ngodhe and Uwi primary schools, alongside secondary-school learners and the wider community. Its users will not only be pupils and students. Teachers, parents, youth and other community members will also have a place to study, read and access information.

That is what makes this story bigger than a library. It goes further to address access, community memory sitting right before our eyes and a story of giving back.

Do we only want to open the structure doors?- it's way beyond that!

We look forward to reading clubs, weekend study sessions and holiday reading programmes and contests, planned to activate the space and turn the building into a living centre of learning.

With time, the project can grow beyond its first structure and first 1,000 books. Future phases may introduce improved infrastructure, a larger collection, ICT facilities, online learning access and more structured community learning programmes.

USAO Community Resource Centre,

- ✓ A place to Read
- ✓ A place to Learn
- ✓ A place to Grow
- ✓ A place to Succeed



A handwritten signature in blue ink, which appears to read "Kenneth Aloo", is positioned above a solid black horizontal line.

Kenneth Aloo